

PTM Preparation Guide — Elementary Program (Expanded Prose Edition)

This document is an expanded version of the original PTM preparation guide. It keeps the same school positions and the same factual content, but presents them in fuller prose so that newer teachers can understand the intent behind the messaging and respond with more confidence and consistency.

The aim of this version is not to add new policy, new promises, or new interpretation. It is only to make the original guidance easier to read, easier to internalize, and easier to use in conversation with parents.

Section 1: Academic Learning at Home

1.1 Internet & AI Tools

Parent question: *Can my child use internet resources and AI tools for their research work and assignments at home?*

School position: Students must refrain from using internet resources and AI tools for their work. The elementary program is not the time to introduce these tools.

When this question comes up, teachers should answer with clarity and without hesitation. The school's view is that elementary-aged children should be doing the mental work of reading, understanding, and summarizing for themselves. At this stage, that process matters more than speed, convenience, or access to direct answers. We want children to build the habits of thinking, processing, and expressing ideas in their own words.

AI tools work against that goal because they often provide ready-made answers. That bypasses the very work we are trying to cultivate. Even when such tools appear efficient, the school's judgment is that, for children of this age, the costs outweigh the benefits. This is also not a question of access: the school already has well-stocked classroom libraries, and additional reading material can be provided when needed.

In conversation with parents, the message should remain calm and direct. Teachers can explain that the program does not direct children to do internet research, and that parents should kindly redirect their child toward offline materials. It is also appropriate to say that the school has experimented with these tools in the past and has found clearly that, at this age, the disadvantages are greater than the advantages. There may be a time and place for such tools later, introduced in a controlled way, but that time is not now.

1.2 Homework Philosophy

Parent question: *How much homework does my child get? Should they be doing more work at home?*

School position: We do not assign explicit homework. Work is designed to be completed during school hours.

Teachers should communicate that the elementary program is intentionally designed so that children can complete their work in school. We do set deadlines, and students are expected to learn how to work toward them, but this should not be described as conventional homework. The expectation is that a reasonably organized child has enough time in school to complete what is required.

There are, however, limited situations in which work may go home. If a child has not prioritized well, they may occasionally need to finish something at home in order to meet a deadline. That is acceptable, but it should not become the norm. Similarly, in particularly busy periods, which happen only once or twice in a year, some work may go home simply because of timing. These are exceptions, not the general philosophy.

If a parent reports that their child is bringing work home regularly, teachers should understand that as a possible prioritization issue rather than as evidence that the school assigns homework. That can be discussed with the family if needed. The larger message is that home time should not be filled with school-like work. It should be a space for reading, hobbies, play, pursuing interests, and, if the child chooses, using MindSpark.

1.3 How to Support Learning at Home

Parent question: *What should evenings and weekends look like? Should I be teaching my child anything? My child says "nothing happened at school" — how do I engage?*

School position: Unless we explicitly ask you, do not teach your child at home. Let them live out their childhood.

This is one of the most important messages in the guide, and new teachers should be especially careful to hold the line here. The school does not want parents turning the home into an extension of the classroom. Unless the school has explicitly asked for academic support in a specific case, parents should not be teaching subjects at home, assigning extra drills, or trying to supplement school work on their own.

What should children be doing instead? They should be living a full childhood. That includes going outside and playing, spending time with friends, joining sports or hobby classes, reading for pleasure, and playing family games, including card games, strategy games, language games, and math games. These are not lesser activities. They are part of a rich life and support healthy development.

Parents do have an important role, but it is not the role of instructor. Their role is to model a life of curiosity and engagement. They can share their own love of reading, writing, and learning. They can talk about their hobbies, their work day, and their own experiences. They can take children to live performances, concerts, and cultural events. They can introduce children to culture through travel and lived experience. They can help children see the best of human accomplishment and create a home environment in which curiosity, conversation, reading, and learning are valued.

Teachers should also guide parents away from unhelpful habits. Parents should not pressure a child to narrate the school day on demand. A better approach is for adults to share their own day first and allow conversation to emerge more naturally. Above all, time should not be wasted on forced teaching when the child could instead be experiencing life more fully.

There are rare situations in which the school may tell a particular family that some supplementation is needed. If that happens, it will be communicated clearly and specifically. Until then, parents should wait for school guidance before adding academic work at home.

Section 2: Reading & Writing Development

2.1 Vocabulary & Independent Reading

Parent question: *My child doesn't enjoy reading independently because they don't understand the meaning of many words. Their reading fluency is good, but they keep asking the meaning of words. How can they become an independent reader?*

School position: The challenge here is vocabulary, not fluency. This is a long journey that takes time.

Teachers should help parents distinguish clearly between decoding and understanding. A child may be able to read words aloud smoothly and still struggle to understand what those words mean. In such cases, the problem is not reading fluency. It is vocabulary. That distinction matters, because the support needed is different.

One useful way to explain this is to point out that if more than about 10% of the words in a book are unfamiliar, reading quickly becomes uncomfortable and unrewarding. A child in that situation is not resisting reading because they are lazy or unmotivated. They are encountering text that is too demanding at the level of meaning.

The support, therefore, should focus on matching books to the child's vocabulary level, not simply to their ability to pronounce words. Books may contain words that are somewhat hard to decode, but the meanings should still be accessible enough that the child can remain independent and enjoy the experience. That is the path toward independent reading.

At home, adults can help by using rich vocabulary naturally in daily life. Audiobooks can also be useful, especially in homes where adults do not themselves use a wide range of vocabulary. Hearing rich language matters. But teachers should emphasize patience: vocabulary growth is a long journey, and there is no quick fix.

2.2 Spelling Errors in Writing

Parent question: *My child can recall the correct spelling verbally, but makes errors when writing. Even when pointed out, they don't always correct it.*

School position: We encourage parents to step back rather than intervene on spelling.

Teachers should explain that spelling problems are not all the same. In some cases, a child truly does not know the correct spelling, which is a knowledge gap. In other cases, the child does know the spelling but executes it incorrectly while writing. The situation described in this question is the second kind: an execution or transcription issue rather than a lack of knowledge.

That kind of issue is already being addressed in school. Children are supported through editing checklists, peer spelling checks, and the broader spelling development work that is part of the program. The school's view is that these mechanisms are sufficient, and that routine parental correction is not necessary.

Teachers should be especially careful about the emotional sequence of feedback. When a child has put effort into a piece of writing, the first response should not be a list of spelling mistakes. Parents should be encouraged to attend first to the substance of the work: what the child is trying to say, the ideas they are sharing, and the meaning they are making. Even when spelling errors are visible, it is worth asking whether spelling feedback is needed at all in that moment. If the school requires additional help from parents on spelling, the school will ask explicitly.

2.3 Creative Writing

Parent question: *What strategies can help my child develop creative writing skills?*

School position: Creative writing development is within the ambit of school work.

Teachers should reassure parents that creative writing is not being neglected and does not need to be separately coached at home. The school already runs a rich creative expression program in which children write across different genres and practice writing in varied forms.

The role of the parent is not to sit the child down and teach creative writing techniques. Instead, parents can help by modeling a genuine love of writing. They can share poems, short stories, diary entries, or other forms of writing that matter to them. The key is to present writing as something alive and joyful rather than as another area of instruction. The school handles the formal development. The parent's contribution is to create a culture in which writing is seen as meaningful and pleasurable.

2.4 Writing Resistance

Parent question: *My child shows resistance towards writing at home. How can I help?*

School position: This is not the parents' role to solve. Writing resistance cannot be resolved by making students do more writing — that is counterproductive.

New teachers should be ready to say this plainly. When a child resists writing, the answer is not to assign more writing at home. More pressure usually worsens the problem rather than solving it. The school's stance is that forced practice is counterproductive in this area.

What parents can do instead is model the value of writing in ordinary life. They can write shopping lists, keep a diary, or write about things that genuinely interest them. In other words, they should show that writing matters in adult life and is not just a school task. The more children see that writing is valued by the people around them, the more naturally they are likely to take it up themselves.

Parents should not force writing practice, present writing as a chore, or pressure the child to produce written work at home. The posture should be invitational and modeled, not coercive.

Section 3: School Programs & Assessment

3.1 Personalized Learning Groups (formerly internal: BUDS Program)

Parent question: *My child is part of a special group. How has this helped? Will it continue?*

Note to teachers: Do not use the internal program name with parents. Refer to it as "personalized learning support" or "small group instruction."

Teachers should be careful both in language and in tone when discussing this support. With parents, this should be described as personalized learning support or small group instruction, not by the internal program name. The purpose of the program is to support children who have shown slightly different needs, especially in situations where more structure, less distraction, or more direct support is beneficial.

For part of the day, these students receive one-on-one or very small group instruction. In many cases, the support is especially helpful for children who need more scaffolding around executive function, including planning, choosing work, and working with self-direction. The learning environment is also quieter, with less movement and fewer distractions, so that attention and focus are easier to sustain.

Teachers should understand the three main benefits clearly. First, the program removes some of the executive function demand by giving children a structured set of carefully designed workbooks in English, Math, and Science, rather than expecting them to plan and organize their own work in the same way. Second, it reduces distraction by creating a calmer environment. Third, it allows for personalized pacing, with the right work at the right time and the right level of support.

The messaging to parents is important. This is not a separate school, and it must not be presented as a hierarchy or caste system. Students remain part of the overall community and participate in it; this support applies only for certain parts of the day. Different children experience it differently, and the school fully intends to continue the program. The larger educational idea underneath it is the personalization of education for all children.

If comparison with conventional schooling comes up, teachers can say that conventional systems may provide more structure, but they typically do not provide this degree of personalized one-on-one support. The school believes that the combination of structure and individualized instruction is particularly valuable for these children's development.

3.2 Group Placement

Parent question: *My child has heard about a different group doing different work. Why aren't they in that group? Can we get them in?*

School position: Group placement is within the teacher's professional remit.

Teachers should respond to this with professional confidence. Group placement is not a matter for parental preference or negotiation. It is part of the teacher's role and is based on ongoing observation and assessment of the child.

Placement decisions are made on the basis of present ability and interest, with the aim of giving the child the greatest likelihood of immediate success and meaningful progress. Because teachers are working with children continuously, they are in the best position to judge when a child is ready to move to another group. Parents should therefore be asked to stay out of this process.

If the issue has come to the parent through the child, teachers should remember that the school also handles these questions directly with children. If a child is interested in seeing what another group is doing, that curiosity can be welcomed. The school follows an open lesson policy, and any child who wants to observe another group's lesson is allowed to do so.

3.3 Benchmarking Exams

Parent question: *I heard my child recently wrote some exams. What are these for? Can I see results?*

School position: This was a benchmarking exercise, not school exams. Individual results are not shared per school policy.

Teachers should explain that these were not school examinations in the usual sense. They were benchmarking assessments conducted by Educational Initiatives, a national benchmarking organization. They are taken by students above Grade 3 in English, Math, and Science, and the scale is large, with roughly 50,000 to 1 lakh students taking them across the country.

It is important to communicate that no preparation is required for these assessments. Students simply come and sit for them. Their purpose is not to judge or sort individual children. The school already has its own understanding of individual students. Instead, the purpose is to help the school understand the strengths and weaknesses of the program as a whole and to make data-driven improvements where

needed.

When parents ask about results, teachers should hold the line on school policy: individual student numbers are not shared. It is acceptable to say that, as a school, performance is very strong, with the school in the upper quartile nationally and some classrooms in the top 5-10%. If a parent strongly insists on access to individual numbers, teachers should direct them to the admin or founders rather than taking that discussion on themselves.

There is one proactive expectation teachers should note. If a particular child has scored significantly below expectations, specifically below the 50th percentile, the teacher should proactively mention that there are deficiencies in specific areas. The framing should be that the school already understood this and that the benchmarking has now verified it. Going forward, teachers can also say that this will likely be a regular school process conducted once or twice per year.

3.4 Olympiad Results

Parent question: *My child's Olympiad results don't seem to match what you've told me about their performance. Can you explain?*

School position: Olympiads are NOT a valid benchmark of your child's learning. We do not endorse them.

Teachers should be prepared for this question because Olympiad scores can create confusion for families. The central message is that Olympiad results do not provide a valid picture of the child's learning as understood by the school. The school does not endorse Olympiads as a benchmark.

The reasons should be explained simply. Olympiad content is often aligned to the next grade rather than the child's current grade. The science component is highly memory-based and does not reflect the kind of science the school believes in. The English paper is not considered a good measure of real comprehension. The Math paper is procedural rather than conceptual. The school also notes that Olympiads began here as a student request years ago; they were not adopted because the school considers them educationally sound measures.

Teachers should redirect parents to the measure the school does trust. The Educational Initiatives benchmarking has aligned completely with the school's own observations of children, and that is the valid measure. If a child is independently motivated to prepare for Olympiads and sit them, that is acceptable, but the results should not be treated as a benchmark or a guide to the child's learning. At most, Olympiads offer some exposure to competitive settings. The scores themselves do not mean very much.

3.5 Elementary to Adolescent Transition

Parent question: *As my child moves from elementary to the adolescent program, is there specific work they should do?*

School position: MindSpark and reading are the best preparation.

Teachers should keep this answer simple and focused. The school's guidance is not to create an elaborate transition program at home. The best preparation is continued MindSpark use and regular reading.

The practical recommendation is one hour of math per week and one hour of language per week on MindSpark. If the child wants to do more than that, they may. Alongside this, reading books of personal interest is the single best use of time. The school has repeatedly observed that children who read a great

deal over the summer return noticeably improved.

If parents want a subject-wise answer, teachers can say that for math the recommendation is MindSpark, and for English MindSpark can support grammar and vocabulary, but there is no substitute for reading for pleasure.

Section 4: Screen Time & Summer

4.1 Screen Time Guidance

Parent question: *How much screen time is appropriate? What's the school's view?*

School position: Different screens have different merits and demerits. It's about the type of screen time, not just the amount.

Teachers should avoid giving a simplistic minutes-based answer, because the school's position is more nuanced than that. The key distinction is not only how much screen time a child gets, but what kind of screen is being used and what the child is doing with it.

The school's strongest position is on smartphones. Teachers should say clearly that smartphones are never appropriate for children in this age group. They encourage constant task-switching between apps and are considered absolutely inappropriate for any age child in this context. Parents should never hand a smartphone over to a child.

Tablets used for passive consumption are viewed similarly. They raise the same concerns as smartphones for elementary-aged children and are not recommended as devices for passive viewing or scrolling.

Large screens, such as a television or projector, are different when used as a shared family activity. Watching a movie together once a week can be very good. Nature programs, documentaries, and age-appropriate films can have genuine value when the family watches together and processes the experience together. The sharedness matters.

Computers and laptops can have some value when used as tools and when there is direct one-on-one supervision. Specific uses such as Canva or coding projects may be appropriate. But teachers should still say that the open internet is almost never valuable for elementary children because it tends to encourage passive consumption. Access to the open internet should not happen without direct adult supervision. In the adolescent program, the school does teach certain computer skills through electives, but even there this does not mean general internet access.

MindSpark is the one screen-based tool that is explicitly acceptable. It is a whitelisted, personalized learning tool and is not treated as passive consumption. In school, computers provide access only to MindSpark and not to the general internet, and it is fine for children to use MindSpark at home for practice as well.

The core message teachers should leave parents with is this: use judgment about good screen time versus bad screen time. The real issue is the nature of the activity, not simply the total number of minutes.

4.2 Summer Activities at Home

Parent question: *What can be done at home during summer holidays to keep my child engaged and in touch with learning?*

School position: MindSpark + reading for pleasure.

Teachers should keep the summer recommendation very focused. The school recommends two things: MindSpark and reading for pleasure. There is no need to create a broad menu of academic tasks.

MindSpark is recommended because it is personalized adaptive software that works at the child's current level. The baseline expectation is one hour of math per week and one hour of language per week, done consistently every week rather than pushed to the end of the summer. Some children may need more, and if so the school will communicate that individually. The school's judgment is that this is more useful than assigning books for practice, because no book can match that level of personalization.

The other major recommendation is reading. Children who spend the summer reading for pleasure come back significantly improved, and the school sees this as the single most beneficial thing a child can do over the break. Parents should therefore be encouraged to help the child read books they are genuinely interested in.

4.3 Summer Program

Parent question: *Why is there no summer program this year?*

School position: There IS a summer program — it's just structured differently this year.

Teachers should correct the assumption in the question gently but clearly: the summer program has not been cancelled. It is continuing, but in a different format.

In previous years, the program remained open through the entire summer. This year, the structure has been consolidated. Younger students will attend for the full month of May, while older students will attend for part of May. The reasoning behind this change should be explained practically. Attendance over the years has been low, and bringing students together into one segment allows for better instruction. It also allows teachers to take coordinated breaks and return refreshed, and it creates time for teacher training that was difficult to fit into the earlier format.

The message to parents should therefore be straightforward: the summer program is very much continuing; it simply looks different this year.

Section 5: Social, Behavioral & Well-being

5.1 Social Conflicts & Friendships

Parent question: *My child is having social problems at school — conflicts with peers, exclusion, etc.*

Teachers should begin this conversation by normalizing the existence of social conflict without dismissing the parent's concern. In Montessori classrooms, children talk, interact, and collaborate freely. Because of that, social conflicts are more visible than they may appear in traditional schools, where student interaction is often suppressed. The school sees this visibility not as evidence of dysfunction, but as a natural byproduct of children learning to live and work together.

It may help teachers to think of social conflict in three levels:

Type	Severity	School Response
Physical misconduct (pushing, hitting)	Unacceptable	Immediately stopped and parents informed

Type	Severity	School Response
Name-calling / inappropriate language	Serious	Students coached; some tolerance as they learn, but firm action if repeated; parents informed
Quiet exclusion (implicit, not overt)	Most challenging	Ongoing work on grace and courtesy; cannot force friendships but insist on inclusion

Quiet exclusion deserves special care in conversation because it is often the hardest for parents to understand and the hardest for schools to fully resolve. It tends to be more common in upper elementary because overt bullying is usually caught quickly. This kind of exclusion is often not explicit. It happens indirectly, and it takes sustained adult engagement with students to address it. The school cannot force one child to be another child's friend, but it can insist on courtesy and inclusion. Teachers should also recognize that this area is complicated and is often entangled with personality differences.

When speaking to parents, the line should be steady. If the issue had reached the level of physical misconduct or repeated name-calling, the school would already have acted and informed the family. The quieter forms of exclusion are harder, but the school does work on them actively. This, too, is part of children's learning about community.

5.2 Behavior & Discipline

Parent question: *How does the school handle misbehavior? What consequences exist?*

School philosophy: Restorative justice.

Teachers should describe the school's disciplinary approach as restorative rather than punitive. The goal is not merely to stop incidents from happening, and it is not to impose punishment for its own sake. The goal is to help students reflect on what they have done, understand the impact of their behavior on others, and learn from the experience.

Conversation is the primary tool of restoration. Reflection is built into the elementary program, and teachers also use stories and similar tools to depersonalize situations so that children can think more independently and honestly about conduct. This is an important part of how the school approaches moral and social growth.

If parents ask what consequences exist, teachers can describe the escalation path clearly. The first level is reflection and conversation, in which the student is helped to think about what happened and what could be done differently. The second level is parent involvement when behavior crosses limits and adult coaching and counseling are needed. The third level, used in severe situations, may involve reduced school time. This is often connected to significant difficulty with impulse control and is decided case by case in the interest of both the child and the wider student group.

5.3 "My Child Seems Behind"

Parent question: *My child's friend is doing multiplication but mine is still on addition. Should I be worried? Other schools seem further ahead in the syllabus.*

This question usually contains two comparisons, and teachers should separate them. One comparison is between children within the school. The other is between schools.

Within the school, teachers should explain that there is a natural window of development. It is normal for some children to be ahead in one area and others to be behind in that same area at a given moment. As

long as the child is within the acceptable developmental window, there is no reason for concern. Teachers use professional judgment to determine pacing, and if the school believes that a child is falling behind that natural window, the school will say so explicitly. If no such concern is being communicated, parents should understand that things are within range.

Across schools, teachers should make it clear that these comparisons are not very meaningful. Different schools sequence content differently, even though they broadly converge by 9th and 10th grade. Traditional schools may emphasize memorization of knowledge, while this school emphasizes understanding and lived experience. Because the goals and sequencing differ, it is not an apples-to-apples comparison. The Montessori elementary curriculum is also broad and deep, and some gaps relative to conventional schooling are intentional rather than accidental.

The final message to parents should be to focus on the skills their child is acquiring rather than on whether another child or another school is covering a particular topic earlier. If the school is worried, the school will say so. And for every child, regular reading for pleasure remains the strongest accelerator.

5.4 Hindi/Kannada Without Home Exposure

Parent question: *How can I help my child progress in Hindi or Kannada when we don't have any exposure to these languages at home?*

School position: Keep expectations low and be patient.

Teachers should answer this honestly. Language develops through immersion, which is the same way children learned English. In school, Hindi and Kannada are offered only about two days a week. That is not immersive, and it is not daily. Kannada in particular also lacks broad support from the surrounding environment for many families, so the total amount of exposure remains low.

For that reason, progress is expected to be slow. Parents should be encouraged to make peace with that reality rather than measuring the child against unrealistic expectations. If families are very concerned, daily tuitions are one possible route, but teachers should be clear that the school neither endorses nor requires that. The school will continue instruction, but without immersion at home or in the larger community, expectations should remain modest.

5.5 Eating Habits & Water

Parent question: *My child doesn't finish their lunch. They don't drink enough water.*

School position: This is part of the culture of independence we want to develop.

Teachers should present this as part of the school's broader commitment to independence. Children eat as a community, but teachers do not individually coax them through meals or constantly monitor intake as a primary responsibility. Finishing lunch and drinking water are understood to be the child's responsibility within that culture.

That does not mean teachers ignore it completely. When teachers notice an issue, they do speak to the child. But this is not a central teacher goal during the day. Parents should therefore be encouraged to create their own systems and expectations with the child at home. The same principle applies to water bottles as well.

5.6 Responsible at School, Not at Home

Parent question: *My child is very responsible at school and completes tasks, but at home they don't take care of things.*

School position: This is outside the scope of our PTM conversation.

Teachers should not let PTM conversations drift too far into areas the school has not directly observed. If a parent raises this, the response should be respectful but bounded. There is a great deal of literature available on this general issue, and parents can be directed to read more online or ask Delphi.

The key point is that PTM time should remain focused on what the school has actually observed in school. Parents can also be directed toward observation conversations where such themes are discussed more broadly as a community, but this specific PTM conversation should not become a general parenting consultation.

Quick Reference: Key Themes Across All Topics

Theme	Message
Parent role	Model behavior, don't teach. Share your life, interests, and love of learning.
School role	We handle instruction. If we need your help, we will ask explicitly.
Comparison	Don't compare your child to others or to other schools.
No news = good news	If we're not raising a concern, your child is within acceptable range.
Reading	The single most impactful thing a child can do at home.
Writing	Focus on content, not mechanics. Model it, don't force it.
Screens	Type matters more than amount. No phones/tablets. Family viewing is fine.
Independence	We're building independence. Step back and let the child develop.
Discipline	Restorative, not punitive. Reflection over punishment.
Communication	We will tell you if something needs attention. Trust the process.